



Preparing for Launch

Before taking your business live, build in a prelaunch stage when you can test each component—from branding to product—and tweak as necessary to ensure you achieve the best possible launch.

Preparing to launch

Careful prelaunch planning will ensure that your business is fully prepared for liftoff. This is the time for crucial small-scale testing of your product or service, branding, website, marketing approach, and any other key component of the business. Getting feedback from a sample of your target audience a few months in advance of your launch will give you time to adjust your approach if necessary to address criticisms and to incorporate helpful new ideas.

To keep costs low, discuss your ideas with as many friends, peers, and family members as possible—especially those who match the characteristics of your target customer (see pp.40–41). Show them what you plan to launch and get their honest opinions.

Ask those who match your target customer profile which social media or internet forums they use; their preferences will help you decide which external

groups to survey to gain more objective judgments. If building a new website to support your business, consider creating a landing page with a form to get on your waiting list to be let in the launch.

30,000
new products are
introduced to the market
each year—95% fail

Clayton Christensen, Harvard Business School

Test strategy

Having created a product to appeal to a certain audience, you now need to find out where those people gather (virtually or physically) and seek their opinions. Approach them via a website that sells your type of product, host a brief online survey, conduct shopping-center or store interviews, or use a focus group, if affordable.

Testing and trialing

Methods for refining your product include click-testing on a website frequented by your target customers; running a trial in a store; and holding a pop-up event.

Feedback mechanisms

Talk to family, friends, and colleagues. Online, budget for a brief survey; question customer groups; set up a web page to solicit reactions and advice.

